

SOCIAL ENGINEERING TECHNIQUES

Social engineering techniques can be categorized based on how attackers manipulate people to reveal confidential information, perform unauthorized actions, or grant access to systems. While the methods vary, they all exploit human psychology rather than technical vulnerabilities.

Technique	Description	Example
Email-Based		
Phishing	Fraudulent emails or messages that appear to come from a legitimate organization to trick victims into revealing credentials or clicking malicious links.	An email claiming to be from your bank asking you to verify your account information.
Spear Phishing	A targeted form of phishing directed at a specific individual or organization using personalized information.	An email addressed to a university professor mentioning a current research project and requesting login verification.
Whaling	A phishing attack specifically targeting high-ranking executives or senior officials.	A fake email sent to a CEO requesting approval for an urgent financial transaction.
Business Email Compromise (BEC)	An attacker compromises or spoofs a business email account to request money transfers or confidential information.	The finance department receives an email appearing to come from the company president requesting an urgent wire transfer.
Phone-Based		
Vishing	Voice phishing using telephone calls or voice messages.	Someone pretending to be from the bank calls and asks you to confirm your account number and OTP.
Pretexting	The attacker invents a believable story or false identity to persuade the victim to disclose information.	A caller pretends to be an IT technician who needs your password to fix your computer.
Mobile-Based		
Smishing	Phishing conducted through SMS or text messages.	A text message claiming you have won a prize and asking you to click a link.
Physical Attacks		
Tailgating (Piggybacking)	Gaining unauthorized physical access by following an authorized person into a restricted area.	An individual carrying boxes asks an employee to hold the secure office door open.
Shoulder Surfing	Observing someone entering confidential information such as passwords or PINs.	Watching someone enter their ATM PIN or office login password.
Dumpster Diving	Searching discarded documents or devices for confidential information.	Retrieving printed payroll reports or customer records from an unsecured trash bin.
Baiting	Offering something attractive to entice victims into performing an action that compromises security.	Leaving a USB drive labeled "Employee Salary List" in a company parking lot, hoping someone plugs it into a computer.

Source: ChatGPT using the prompt "what are the different social engineering techniques".

Technique	Description	Example
Online and Social Media		
Impersonation	Pretending to be a trusted person or authority to gain access or information.	An attacker wears a delivery uniform and claims to be delivering equipment to enter a restricted office.
Honey Trap (Romance Scam)	Building a personal or romantic relationship to gain trust and eventually obtain money or confidential information.	Someone develops an online relationship before asking for financial assistance or sensitive company information.
Watering Hole Attack	Compromising a website frequently visited by the intended victims to infect their devices.	Attackers compromise an industry association's website knowing employees regularly visit it.
Multiple Communication Methods		
Quid Pro Quo	Offering a service or benefit in exchange for information or access.	Someone offers free technical support if the employee provides their login credentials.
Scareware	Displaying fake warnings or security alerts to frighten users into installing malicious software or paying for fake services.	A pop-up claims that your computer is infected and instructs you to download a "security tool."
Reverse Social Engineering	The attacker creates a problem and then presents themselves as the person who can solve it, causing victims to seek their help voluntarily.	An attacker disrupts a printer, then offers "technical support" and asks for administrator credentials.

COMMUNICATION METHODS USED IN SOCIAL ENGINEERING

Technique	Email	Phone	SMS	Social Media	Website / Pop-Up	In-Person	Physical
Phishing	✓						
Spear Phishing	✓			✓			
Whaling	✓						
Smishing			✓				
Vishing		✓					
Pretexting	✓	✓	✓	✓		✓	
Baiting	✓					✓	✓
Quid Pro Quo	✓	✓				✓	
Scareware	✓				✓		
Reverse Social Engineering	✓	✓				✓	
Tailgating						✓	
Shoulder Surfing						✓	
Dumpster Diving							✓
Impersonation	✓	✓		✓		✓	

Source: ChatGPT using the prompt "what are the different social engineering techniques".

PSYCHOLOGICAL TACTICS USED IN SOCIAL ENGINEERING

Psychological Tactic	Example
Authority	"I'm from the IT Department."
Urgency	"Respond within 30 minutes or your account will be suspended."
Fear	"Your bank account has been compromised."
Curiosity	"Confidential Salary Adjustments 2026.xlsx"
Greed	"Claim your ₱10,000 reward now!"
Trust/Familiarity	Pretending to be a coworker, classmate, or friend.
Sympathy	Asking for help because of an alleged emergency.
Scarcity	"Only the first 50 users will receive this benefit."
Reciprocity	Offering free gifts, software, or assistance in exchange for information.

Source: ChatGPT using the prompt "what are the different social engineering techniques".